ROOTED TOGETHER

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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

Bringing together young adults seeking cultural connection and seniors facing social isolation and loneliness in the community to help improve the quality of life of seniors and young adults.

Utilizing a strengths based approach, incorporating the goals and skills of seniors and youth into day to day activities to foster mutual growth.

In doing this we are also decreasing the physical and mental ailments associated with social isolation and loneliness. This is also helping to reduce the strain in Healthcare industries.

"BEING HUMAN ALWAYS POINTS, AND IS DIRECTED, TO SOMETHING, OR SOMEONE, OTHER THAN ONESELF—BE IT MEANING TO FULFILL OR ANOTHER HUMAN BEING TO ENCOUNTER

- VICTOR FRANKL

PROBLEM STATEMENT

ISOLATION CRISIS

- **19%** of seniors 65+ experienced **loneliness**, **22%** in **immigrant** populations
- **43%** of seniors at risk for **social isolation**
- Isolation accelerate **chronic, mental and cognitive ailments**
- **80%** of seniors wish to **age in place** but many lack the support to sustain this

CULTURAL DISSONANCE

- **18.7% of second-gen immigrant youth** report full assimilation
- **Acculturative stress:** Struggle to balance Canadian society and cultural identity.
- **Mental health effects:** Cultural disconnect can lead to **declining mental well-being, family conflict, etc.**

Top Reasons Limiting Social Engagement:

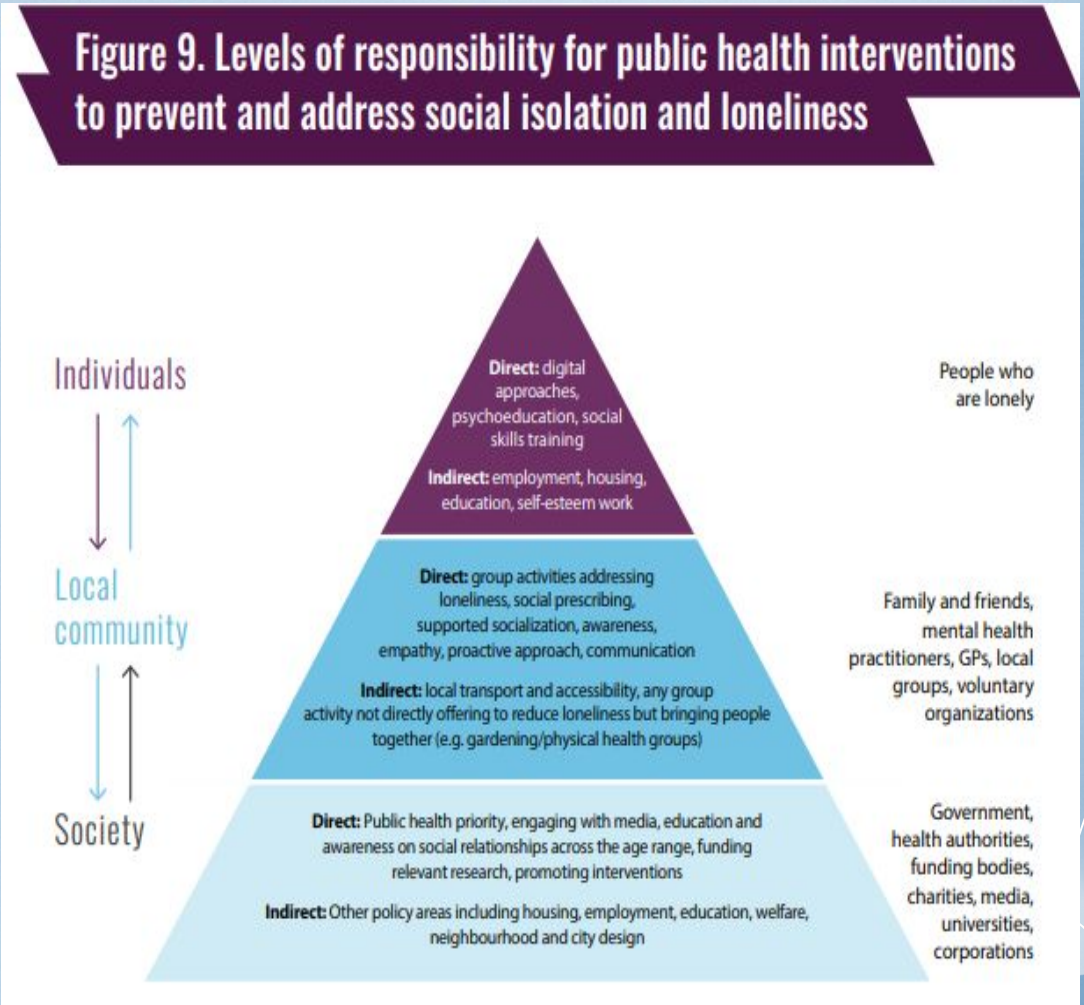
- **42%** Lack of funds/activities cost more than I could afford
- **31%** Health condition limits what I can do
- **28%** Do not have anyone to go with/do not want to do them alone
- **26%** Lack of energy to do more
- **23%** Activity timing or schedule is inconvenient/doesn't work with my schedule

PROPOSED SOLUTION

- This picture is from Canadian Coalition for Seniors Mental Health (CCSMH) that represents levels of responsibility to prevent and address social isolation and loneliness. Our solution primarily focus on local community while touching on individuals.

- CCSMH released "Canadian Clinical Guidelines on Social Isolation and Loneliness in Older Adults" we used their guidelines as stepping stones to come up with a comprehensive solution.

- The main idea of the principles is to focus on integrate diverse voices, consider cultural and individual contexts, using evidence-based practices, and prioritizing marginalized groups while promoting a strengths-based approach.



PROPOSED SOLUTION

Our solution to support the aging population in Canada is a community-based program aimed at preventing social isolation while improving the physical and mental well-being of both volunteers and seniors, ultimately reducing strain on the healthcare system. We bring together a taskforce of young adults (e.g., high school and university/college students) who will receive specialized training to run the program, developed with input from physical therapists, occupational therapists, geriatric specialists, and, most importantly, input from both seniors and youth. Volunteers are paired with seniors based on shared interests and compatibility.

The core of this solution is a wheelchair accessible transport service, available three times a week, that will pick up seniors in the community and bring them to a location for the day's activity. With most activities taking place outdoors to reap the benefit from fresh air and sunlight. The transport service will also serve as a grocery shuttle, bringing groceries to seniors who are unable to visit stores or lack family support.

PROPOSED SOLUTION

Each day will feature physical, social, and cognitive activities, helping reduce social isolation and improve motor skills. Additionally, seniors will have the opportunity to teach and share knowledge with the young adults, promoting a sense of purpose and meaning, which often diminishes with age. The seniors could teach them language, heritage practices and just fun craftsmanship. Creating inclusive spaces that celebrates cultural diversity can help immigrant youth feel they belong, reconnected with their heritage and it strengthens their identity.

This solution serves as a preventive measure to improve physical and mental fitness and enhance the quality of life for both seniors and volunteers.

OUR UNIQUE VALUE

Audience

- Our program focuses on seniors **aging at home/in place**
  a. Thrive while maintaining independence
  b. Reaching **immigrant** seniors living alone/with family
- **Small group pairings** (2-5) for more personal connection

Cultivating Sense of Purpose and Reconnection

- **Seniors** do not just learn, they **give back to youth, teaching skills and culture.**

- Providing **youth** facing **disconnect** with **cultural identity** the chance to **reconnect** and form **community**

IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

Phase 1: Research & Planning (Month 1-2)

- Conduct Market research on similar programs and best practices
- Identify key community partners (community centers, cultural organizations, senior homes, universities, local businesses)
- Survey elderly and volunteers in activities of interest
- Define program objectives, structure, logistics such as volunteer training, activity schedules, cultural integration
- Secure funding (grants, sponsorships, fundraising)
- Develop safety protocols for mental well being support and physical injury prevention

Phase 2: Recruitment & Training (Month 3-4)

- Recruit elderly participants from communities, senior homes, cultural organizations, door to door canvassing
- Recruit youth volunteers though universities, cultural organizations, and social media
- Advertise in local and cultural communities, social media (Instagram, tiktok)
- Offer volunteer incentives such as service hours, certifications, and the cultural benefit
- Conduct orientation sessions for both groups to explain the program's benefits and expectations
- Provide training to volunteers on elderly care, communication skills, and cultural sensitivity
- Partner with professionals physiotherapists to design exercise routines and activities while ensuring safety

IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

Phase 3: Pilot Program & Feedback (Month 5-6)

- Launch a small scale pilot with limited number of participants
- Implement structured sessions with a mix of cultural exchange, activities can include crafts, storytelling, music and dance
- Sessions can include physical exercises like dance, yoga, short nature walks
- Collect feedback from participants to assess engagement, challenges, and improvements
- Run focus groups alongside surveys for qualitative insights
- Adjust program structure based on feedback and observed impact
- A Mentorship pair system (elderly-youth buddy system) is implemented to enhance engagement

Phase 4: Full Implementation (Month 7-12)

- Expand the program to reach more participants and establish a sustainable schedule
- Strengthen partnerships with local businesses and cultural groups to support activities
- Organize larger cultural events where elderly and youth can showcase their shared experiences
- The crafts can be sold at events, flea markets, and local businesses to help support the program and it's elderly participants
- Host themed activity days such as cultural food days and storytelling sessions to maintain excitement
- Develop volunteer training module for easier scalability
- Monitor impact through survey and feedback
- Focus on social connection, mental well being, and physical health improvements

IMPLEMENTATION PLAN

Phase 5: Growth & Sustainability (Year 2)

- Scale the program to additional locations based on demand and success metrics
- Seek long term function through grants, corporate sponsorships and government support
- Establish a leadership team within volunteer group to ensure program continuity
- Publish success stories and impact reports to gain media attention and increase community engagement
- Develop a digital platform (website or blog) to streamline program management and engagement tracking
- Enhance visibility by contacting local news and community features

IMPACT ANALYSIS

In addition to fostering connections, our program aims to support seniors' physical and mental well-being, helping them maintain independence and autonomy.

Our program includes specialized physical activities to help seniors improve mobility and balance, reducing the risk of fall-related injuries.

Social isolation and loneliness are also closely linked to cardiovascular disease and dementia.

We prioritize outdoor activities, allowing participants to benefit from sunlight, which boosts immunity by increasing white blood cell count, releases endorphins, and helps lower blood pressure and anxiety.

We'll keep seniors cognitively engaged with stimulating activities and reduce food insecurity by offering transportation to grocery stores or having youth deliver groceries directly.

Immigrant youth often struggle to balance assimilation with preserving their cultural identities, leading to lost language and traditions and communication barriers, especially with grandparents. This can cause feelings of isolation and disconnection from their roots. By connecting them with elders who can share cultural knowledge, we help them regain their identity, self-confidence, and sense of belonging.

IMPACT ANALYSIS

Aging population strains the healthcare system. Seniors who are socially isolated make more doctor visits, frequent emergency rooms, use more medication, and enter residential care sooner. As the proportion of elderly in nursing homes increases, this puts a strain on nursing homes and the staff working there.

The combination of short staffing and high demand can lead to longer wait times and deteriorating health for patients.

By reducing social isolation and improving health, we can lessen the demand for medical care, easing the burden on the healthcare system, reducing wait times, and lightening the load on healthcare workers.

Our solution also aims to reduce healthcare expenditures on senior care. In Canada, the estimated annual cost of senior care to the healthcare system is expected to reach $40 billion.

By being preventative, we reduce the need for visits to physicians, nursing homes, and emergency rooms.

Research shows that social isolation among seniors increases the likelihood of nursing home admissions, and programs that promote socialization can help lower healthcare costs.

FEASIBILITY ~ COST & FINANCES

Costs	
Physiotherapist	**Part time ⇒ $33,230** ($32/hr)
Geriatric Medicine Specialist	**2 week consultation ⇒ $3,999** ($49.99/hr x 80hr)
Volunteer Coordinator	**Full time ⇒ $39,998 (19.23/hr)**
Marketing	**$1000**
Supplies/Activity Resources/Resources	**$4,000** (Gas: 2,753.71, Supplies: 1246.29)
Van/Shuttle	**Seeking donation/partnership**
	$82,227

Government Grants	
New Horizons for Seniors Program	**$25,000/yr** Federal grants for programs that seek to empower seniors and improve their QOL/wellbeing through participation in community.
Seniors Community Grant Program (Ontario)	**$1000 - 25,000/yr** **Provincial** grant for programs that help seniors live independently, avoid isolation, stay connected with community and achieve greater financial security
Foundation/Corporation Grants	
Sienna For Seniors Grant	**One time $50,000 grant** For programs that fund innovative, impactful programs that foster joy, social connection, and well-being for seniors in communities across Canada
Shannex Cares	**$2,500 grant** For programs that support seniors in the areas of Seniors' Wellness, Seniors' Active Living, and Seniors' Social Connections.
	$102,500

FEASIBILITY ~ COST & FINANCES PT.2

Large-scale implementation of our program can be costly, and as undergrad students without NPO status we can't access many grants listed in the previous slide. Instead, this slide outlines possible avenues for realistic fundraising and cost-cutting strategies in order to run a small-scale pilot program as students.

Our smaller scaled program would omit services such as grocery runs and shuttles. Rather, we would focus more on gauging the success and interest rates of the personalized cultural and intergenerational programing among the senior and student audience.

Fundraising	
Form a USC ratified club	- Funds from club membership fees - Access to USC club affiliated grants - Convenient recruitment of student volunteers and hosting of fundraisers
Small Scale Fundraisers	- Bake sales, gift card/prize draw, crowdfund campaign
Partnerships with London organizations	Reaching out to local organizations/community centers/programs to cut costs and aid in: - Marketing - Program venue - Senior volunteer recruitment *Details on our current partner research can be found here.*
Faculty/Program/USC grants	Research into student focused grants such Student Opportunity Fund, USC club grants, etc. to see if our project would qualify.

FEASIBILITY ~ RECRUITMENT

VOLUNTEERS

Target Volunteer Base: Young adults, particularly second generation immigrants who want to reconnect with their cultural identities but lack the opportunities (Still open to volunteers of all backgrounds as long as vulnerability checks met)

- Over ⅓ immigrant children in Canada speak only English/French at home, highlighting disconnect from cultural roots
- **Cultural detachment** is linked to acculturation stress and a **lack of belonging**, negatively affecting mental health and identity.
  - Our program seeks to help recruit such volunteers to learn native languages and cultural practices from seniors while they support seniors through their goals as well

Recruitment Channels:

- University/Post-secondary campus and clubs
- Language learning centers
- Cultural community centers and organizations
- Social media

SENIORS

Recruitment Channels:

- Senior **organizations** and **community centers**
- **Door-to-door canvassing/outreach** and cold calls to reach seniors who are not presently involved in community, or are/have caregivers who are unaware of existing programs,

SCALABILITY

Rural seniors: often lack nearby services. Our program is community led so our activities are local and transport is provided.

We understand that elderly individuals in rural areas likely face challenges, such as limited access to groceries, so our grocery program will make healthy food more convenient and accessible.

Immigrant seniors: Face social isolation due to language barriers, lack of awareness of resources, and limited cultural connections. With family members occupied with work and school, they are frequently left alone without support. Refugees may experience even greater isolation while processing trauma in an unfamiliar environment. Our community-based solution aims to pair seniors with someone who shares their language or culture, or, if unavailable, a youth eager to engage and learn from them.

Low-income seniors: Struggle to afford existing programs or transportation to the services. Our free program addresses this by incorporating a volunteer-led initiative with partnered small businesses, allowing seniors to create and sell products for basic financial support. This improvement in Financial security will subsequently further increase mental and physical well being.

Many minority and vulnerable communities face limited digital proficiency, restricting their access to services. To bridge this gap, we incorporate word-of-mouth and door-to-door outreach as part of our marketing strategy, ensuring more people can access the support they need.

CONCLUSION

Our solution is a transformative approach to combating elderly isolation and bridging generational divides, reshaping healthcare by prioritizing social health and mental well-being. By bringing together youth and seniors in culturally integrated activities, we foster a sense of purpose, belonging, and shared responsibility, creating positive ripple effects that extend throughout communities.

This program empowers seniors to regain purpose and combats the mental and physical toll of isolation, while offering youth the opportunity to learn, connect, and grow. Through innovative partnerships, we can scale this initiative nationally, ensuring social connection becomes a cornerstone of health care.

By focusing on preventative care and social engagement, we reduce the burden of chronic conditions tied to isolation, alleviating strain on the healthcare system. Through community driven efforts, we are not just enhancing individual health but building a more inclusive, resilient society—setting the foundation for a future where emotional, social, and physical well being are interconnected creating a stronger, healthier future for all generations.

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